An Introduction to the Thessalonian Church

Paul, Silvanus, and Timothy greet a young church already marked by faith, love, and hope — a church secure in God, praised for the source of its activity, and reached by a gospel that came in word, in power and in the life of the messengers.

Source: Dr. C. Norman Sellers, ThD · SellersBibleInstitute.com · used by permission

Where this study fits

1 Thessalonians · ten studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5
An Introduction to the Thessalonian Church

02 1:6–10
The Many Faces of the Gospel

03 2:1–12
Delivering the Gospel

04 2:13–20
A Successful Life of Service

05 3:1–13
Facing Tribulation

06 4:1–12
A Life That Pleases God

07 4:13–18
The Rapture of the Church

08 5:1–11
The Coming of the Lord: A Purifying Hope

09 5:12–22
The Coming of the Lord: Exhortations

10 5:23–28
'Til We Meet Again

"Finally" (4:1) marks the hinge: chapters 1–3 lay the foundation; chapters 4–5 turn that theology into life.

Paul’s road to Thessalonica

Introduction · Geographical background (Acts 16–18)

A

Lystra & Iconium

Timothy joins the team — Paul and Silas add a young convert

Second journey

B

Troas

The Macedonian call: “Come over and help us”

The Spirit redirects west

C

Philippi

Jail, earthquake, and the jailer: “Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ”

The gospel Paul preached

D

Thessalonica

Three Sabbaths in the synagogue — but he stayed longer

Acts 17:1–9

E

Berea → Corinth

Berea, Athens, then Corinth — where both letters were written

Acts 17–18

Who believed

- Jews and devout Greeks in the synagogue (Acts 17:4)
- Not a few of the leading women

What Paul taught new converts

- Prophecy — Jesus is coming
- And it strengthened them

Three men, one letter

1 Thessalonians 1:1a · I — Paul and His Companions

Paul

The friend, not the apostle

- No title — just “Paul”
- A relationship of mutual love and trust
- Contrast Galatians and Corinthians: “Paul, an apostle”

Silvanus (Silas)

The senior member

- Paul’s chosen partner after the split with Barnabas
- Experience and credibility for the team and the mission

Timothy

The leader in training

- Well spoken of in Lystra and Iconium
- Later sent to Philippi; pastor at Ephesus
- Still in formation here

The absence of the title “apostle” reflects the health of this church. Paul writes as brother, not authority.

An introduction, verse by verse

1 Thessalonians 1:1–5 · Outline points I–III

v.1a	Paul and his companions — no apostolic title needed	**—** Paul writes as brother, not authority
v.1b	To the church … in God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ	**ἐκκλησία** the local assembly in Thessalonica
v.1c	The greeting — “Grace to you and peace”	**χάρις · εἰρήνη** favor in spite of demerit · shalom
v.2	Thanksgiving joined to intercession — “for you all”	**εὐχαριστοῦμεν** a continuous posture of gratitude
v.3	Work of faith, labor of love, patience of hope	**ἔργον · κόπος · ὑπομονή** all sourced in and directed to Christ
v.4	Beloved brethren — your election by God	**ἐκλογή · ἀγαπητοί** God’s sovereign choosing
v.5	The gospel came in word, power, the Spirit and much assurance	**δύναμις · πληροφορία** divine power · full conviction

The church in God and in Christ

1 Thessalonians 1:1b · II.A–B — The church defined and its identity

A

Any assembly

A secular word — even the worshipers of Diana

Acts 19:32

B

Christ takes it

“On this rock I will build My church”

Matt 16:18

C

Church universal

Every believer from Pentecost to the Rapture

The body of Christ

D

Local assembly

“Tell it to the church” — a congregation

Matt 18:17

E

In Thessalonica

Here: the local church in Thessalonica

1 Thess 1:1

In God the Father

- Security
- Love
- The strength of the Father

In the Lord Jesus Christ

- Lord — the title of deity (Jehovah)
- Jesus — Joshua: salvation, deliverer
- Christ — Messiah, the anointed one

Work of faith, labor of love, patience of hope

1 Thessalonians 1:3 · III.B — The content of the prayer

Work of faith
ἔργον ergou · G2041

- Not busy work — work that results from faith
- Seeking God’s will, depending on His power
- Results beyond human expectation

Labor of love
κόπος kopou · G2873

- Stronger than ergon: costly, exhausting toil
- Love for Christ, for each other — and for the lost
- “God so loved the world”

Patience of hope
ὑπομονή hypomonēs · G5281

- Endurance in tribulation
- Active perseverance, not passive waiting
- Produced by hope fixed on Christ

Faith in Christ, love for Christ, endurance looking for Christ — all three have Christ as both their source and their object.

Election: proved to whom?

1 Thessalonians 1:4 · III.C — The core of the prayer

Before God
ἐκλογή eklogē · G1589

- Election is God’s sovereign choosing
- Justification by faith alone
- Abraham believed — Gen 15:6
- My assurance rests on the Word of God

vs

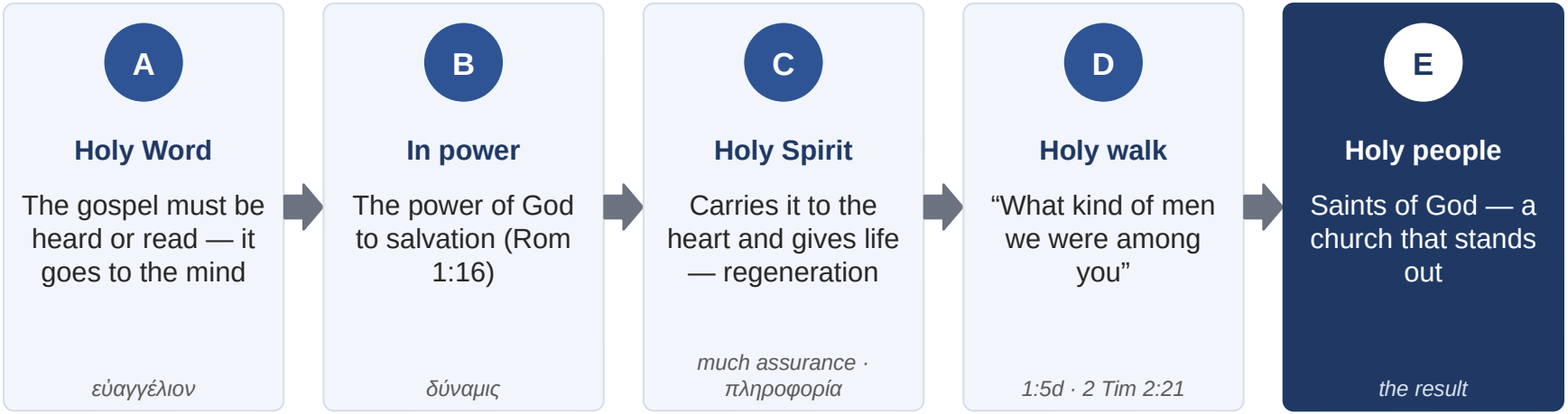
Before men
ἔργον ergon · G2041 · the outworking

- Others know only what they see
- Works are evidence to them (James 2)
- They do not cause election
- Never “faith plus works” for salvation

My works do not prove my election to me — the Word of God does. My works show others what God has already done.

How the gospel came to Thessalonica

1 Thessalonians 1:5 · III.D — The confidence of the prayer



Holy Word + Holy Spirit + holy walk = holy people. We give people the gospel; the Holy Spirit does the rest.

Discuss and apply

1 Thessalonians 1:1–5 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Why does Paul NOT use the title “Apostle” here, as he does in Galatians and 1 Corinthians?

2. How does “dynamis” (power) differ from ordinary human persuasion, and what role does the Holy Spirit play?

Apply

Examine the Source of Your Activity
Before any ministry this week, pray: “Lord, I am doing this because I trust You, love You, and am looking for You.”

Build an Intercessory Prayer List
Write out people in your church by name and pray through the list at least three times this week.

In one line: A church secure in God, busy from the right source, reached by a gospel that came in word, in power and in a holy life.